

CUSTOMS AND BELIEFS

The ancient Egyptians believed that they lived in a well-ordered world, overseen by gods. There were many different gods, who were represented in both human and animal form. For example, the mother goddess Hathor was represented either as a cow or as a woman wearing a horned headdress.

Egyptian temples were believed to be the homes of the gods, who were represented by statues. Here, the gods were treated like living beings and given daily meals and clean clothes. During religious festivals, priests took the gods' statues out of their temples on parades featuring musicians and dancers.

The people of Egypt considered their pharaoh to be a link between humans and the gods. In the Old

Kingdom, a pharaoh was seen as a living god. From the Middle Kingdom, they were considered to be the representatives of the gods on Earth. As pharaohs took the throne, they were transformed into the earthly form of Horus, the hawk-headed sky god. It was believed that after death, they would be united with Horus's father Osiris, the king of the underworld. Egyptians believed that, after death, they could also live again in the kingdom of Osiris, which was a land just like ancient Egypt.

FACT

When making a mummy, the Egyptians carefully preserved every organ except the brain, which they threw away. They thought brains served no purpose!

PROTECTOR GODS

Every part of ancient Egyptian life was protected by a god. While Horus watched over the pharaoh, Hathor cared for mothers. Bes guarded the home against snakes and scorpions, and Anubis looked after the mummification process.

